

Impact: Medium Difficulty: Hard Misuse risk: Low

CORE FORMULA

Still baseline -> Deliberate movement -> Gestures that reinforce the point

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Before your next important conversation or presentation, notice your default physical behaviour. Set a still baseline. Move only when you mean to.

BEST FOR

- Presentations and public speaking
- High-stakes face-to-face conversations
- Situations where physical composure matters
- Any context where nervousness tends to show in movement

PHRASE BANK

Grounding Phrases · Anchoring before you speak

- "Let me say this plainly."
- "I want to be direct about this."
- "The straightforward answer is..."
- "My view, simply: ..."
- "To be clear: ..."
- "The bottom line is..."

Recovery Phrases · When you notice excess movement

- "[Plant feet. Pause. Continue.]"
- "[Still hands. Look at the person. Finish the sentence.]"
- "[Slow the pace. Stop moving. Speak from here.]"

Spoken Anchors · Lines delivered from a planted position

- "I am going to stay right here for this part, because it matters."
- "Let me put everything down and give you the headline."
- "Before I move on, I want to let that point stand for a moment."
- "I will take the next section from just here."
- "Let me stop walking and say this plainly."
- "This is the slide I want us to sit with for a minute."

Stillness as Attention · Settling your body to give someone the floor

- "Let me put my phone away — you have my full attention."
- "I am in no hurry. Take whatever time you need."
- "I am going to sit back and just listen for a while."
- "Nothing about this needs rushing — go on."
- "I am not going anywhere. Start wherever feels right."
- "Let me close the laptop; this deserves better than half of me."

Reading the Room Back In · When stillness or fidgeting is misread

- "I know I have gone very still — that is me concentrating, not switching off."
- "My pacing was nerves, not impatience. Let me stand still and try that again."
- "If I looked restless just then, it was energy, not disinterest."
- "I realise I was talking to the whiteboard, not to you. Let me turn around and say it properly."

- "That stillness was not coldness — I wanted the words to carry the weight."
- "I fidget when I am thinking hard. Ignore the pen; hear the point."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Constant fidgeting, rocking, or pacing while speaking
Better: Standing still but tight.
Best: Relaxed stillness as the default. Deliberate movement to punctuate key points.
2. Weak: Large gestures that do not match the verbal content
Better: Smaller gestures.
Best: Gestures that precisely reinforce what is being said. No more.
3. Weak: Shrinking posture — hunched, small, tight
Better: Upright posture.
Best: Natural upright alignment with relaxed shoulders. No performance, no contraction.

DECISION TREE

If You notice you are fidgeting or moving excessively

Plant your feet or rest your hands. Still baseline. Then continue.

If You need to move to make a point

Move once, deliberately, to make the point. Return to the baseline.

If Your stillness is reading as rigid or cold

Use intentional, warm movement — a lean forward, a gesture. Once. Then return.

If You are presenting and moving constantly around the room

Move to a spot. Plant. Finish the point. Then move again if needed.

SCENARIOS

Presenting to a large audience

Move intentionally to different positions to mark sections. Still between moves. — "[Move to centre. Pause. Open statement. Move right for first main point.]"

High-stakes conversation across a table

Still posture. Lean in slightly for emphasis. Return to baseline. — "[Lean in] This is the key point. [Sit back]"

Delivering difficult news

Very still. Slow. No nervous movement. Let the words carry the weight. — "[Plant. Still. Speak slowly and directly.]"

Nervousness causing excessive movement

Name the ground under your feet. Plant. Breathe. Begin. — "[Ground. Breathe. Begin.]"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- In casual, high-energy social settings where measured movement reads as stiff or unnatural.
- When genuine urgency requires rapid physical movement.
- When your natural movement style is already composed — over-engineering it creates self-consciousness.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Observe your baseline

In one conversation or meeting, notice your physical behaviour. What do you do by default?

Day 2 — Set a still baseline

In one meeting, consciously hold a still posture as your default for the full duration.

Day 3 — Deliberate movement

Move once during a presentation or conversation — intentionally, to reinforce a point. Then return to the baseline.

Day 4 — Grounding under pressure

The next time you feel nervous in a conversation, plant your feet before speaking.

Day 5 — Gesture once

Make one deliberate hand gesture that reinforces your main point. Use it once.

Day 6 — Presentation practice

Present a short piece of content while consciously managing your movement.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did others notice a change? Did you feel more grounded? Did any stillness read as cold?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I set a still baseline before starting?
- Did I move deliberately — not reflexively or nervously?
- Were my gestures reinforcing the content rather than distracting from it?
- Did I avoid fidgeting, pacing, or rocking?
- Did I return to the baseline after deliberate movement?
- Did my physical presence match the gravity of what I was saying?
- Did I feel grounded rather than rigid?